

Figure 3.18 *Chehel Burj, eastern Yakaulang District, Bamiyan Province: unidentified ornamentation. From Lee 2006: fig. 24.*

and lofty interior spaces – all architectural devices associable with the larger Persianate-Islamic world. By contrast, its residential/palatial structures consisted of elliptical corridors (Figure 3.26) directly evoking the pre-Islamic fabric of Zuhak, and exhibiting "horizontal squinches" and corbeled ceilings apparently akin to *Indic* methods of construction.[71] Thus, Sarkhushak not only distinguished itself as one of the rare, newly commissioned constructions quite possibly of Shansabani patronage in the main Bamiyan valleys, it intriguingly reconciled the continuity of the regional architectural culture with discernibly Islamic ritual structures, while integrating Indic building practices as well.

The recent DAFA-led Franco-Afghan excavations at Shahr-i Ghulghula (Figures I.22, 3.12 and 3.13) are germane at this juncture. These investigations have unearthed fascinating indications of more than one phase of